

Believing vs Faith

what is the difference?

Everyone has a rough idea of the difference between these two words so why pursue this? Because building on our own understanding is like building on sand ([Proverbs 3:5](#)) and the wise build upon *the* Rock ([Proverbs 3:6](#)).

Proverbs 4:7

Wisdom is the principal thing; therefore **get wisdom**: and with all thy getting **get understanding**.

- Wisdom and understanding are both obtained *only* from God's word and the Holy Ghost.
 - [Proverbs 2:6](#), [1 Corinthians 3:19](#)

So, let's have a look at God's word and the Holy Ghost give you understanding.

The word *faith* is used three different ways in the new testament: G3640, G4102, and **G1680**. We're going to be looking at the one that is found in [Hebrews 11:1](#), [James 2:14-18](#), [Ephesians 2:8](#), and many others which is G4102 (244x).

Hebrews 11:1

Now faith is the **substance**^{G4102} **of things hoped**^{G1679} **for**, the evidence of things not seen.

- Here is wisdom: a concise definition of what faith is: but what does that mean?
- Side note: G1679 here is "trust" (in the sense of expectation/confidence and not crossing your fingers) and is not connected to **G1680** "faith" (which 54 times is translated as "hope").

Noah Webster's 1828 dictionary defines substance as:

SUB'STANCE, noun. [L. substantia, substō; sub and stō, to stand.]

1. In a general sense, being; something existing by itself; **that which really is or exists**; equally applicable to matter or spirit.

2. That which supports accidents.

That which subsists by itself is called substance; that which subsists in and by another, is called a mode or manner of being.

3. The essential part; the main or **material** part.

4. **Something real, not imaginary**; something **solid**, not empty.

5. Body; corporeal nature or matter.

In **Matthew 9** two blind men come to Jesus asking Him to “*have mercy on us*”.

Matthew 9:27-29

²⁷ And when Jesus departed thence, two blind men followed him, crying, and saying, **Thou Son of David, have mercy on us.**

²⁸ And when he was come into the house, the blind men came to him: and Jesus saith unto them, **Believe ye that I am able to do this?** They said unto him, Yea, Lord.

²⁹ Then touched he their eyes, saying, **According to your faith^{G4102} be it unto you.**

The blind men *followed* Jesus, even *pursued* after Him, and asked Him for mercy. When Jesus asked them “**Believe ye that I am able to do this?**” where did they get their answer from? They got it from something *internal*.

Carefully notice Jesus’ response: “**According to your faith be it unto you.**” He did not say: According to your **belief** be it unto you. He said: according to your **faith**. These men were not rewarded based on what they believed: they were rewarded based on their faith (their actions).

In **Matthew 8** a centurion comes to Jesus and after recounting the situation He simply responds “**I will come and heal him.**” That’s amazing by itself but what transpires next is also enlightening.

Matthew 8:5-13

⁵ And when Jesus was entered into Capernaum, there came unto him a centurion, beseeching him,

⁶ And saying, Lord, my servant lieth at home sick of the palsy, grievously tormented.

⁷ And Jesus saith unto him, **I will come and heal him.**

⁸ The centurion answered and said, Lord, I am not worthy that thou shouldest come under my roof: but speak the word only, and my servant shall be healed.

⁹ For I am a man under authority, having soldiers under me: and I say to this man, Go, and he goeth; and to another, Come, and he cometh; and to my servant, Do this, and he doeth it.

¹⁰ When Jesus heard it, he marvelled, and said to them that followed, **Verily I say unto you, I have not found so great faith^{G4102}, no, not in Israel.**

¹¹ **And I say unto you, That many shall come from the east and west, and shall sit down with Abraham, and Isaac, and Jacob, in the kingdom of heaven.**

¹² **But the children of the kingdom shall be cast out into outer darkness: there shall be weeping and gnashing of teeth.**

¹³ And Jesus said unto the centurion, **Go thy way; and as thou hast believed, so be it done unto thee.** And his servant was healed in the selfsame hour.

In verses **8 & 9** the centurion’s coming to Jesus and speaking are his internal belief on display (and immediately after those are called faith by Jesus). The centurion’s internal belief *manifests* as substance in his actions and his speech. We can confirm this because in verse **10** Jesus says: “...**I have not found so great faith...**”. What did Jesus find and how did He find it? He *found* it with His eyes and ears and what He found was what the centurion just did and said.

The centurion believed and hoped that Jesus could heal his servant. That led to him taking action by going to Jesus and explaining his belief – and *then* Jesus rewarded him.

Luke 5:18-20

¹⁸ And, behold, men brought in a bed a man which was taken with a palsy: and they sought means to bring him in, and to lay him before him.

¹⁹ And when they could not find by what way they might bring him in because of the multitude, they went upon the housetop, and let him down through the tiling with his couch into the midst before Jesus.

²⁰ And when he saw their faith^{G4102}, he said unto him, Man, thy sins are forgiven thee.

- What did Jesus see with His eyes? *Their faith*.
 - The men carrying the man taken with a palsy.
 - They came to Jesus and found a way to get their friend right in front of Jesus.

James 2:14-19

¹⁴ What doth it profit, my brethren, though a man say he hath faith^{G4102}, and have not works? can faith save him?

¹⁵ If a brother or sister be naked, and destitute of daily food,

¹⁶ And one of you say unto them, Depart in peace, be ye warmed and filled; notwithstanding ye give them not those things which are needful to the body; what doth it profit?

¹⁷ Even so faith^{G4102}, if it hath not works, is dead, being alone.

¹⁸ Yea, a man may say, Thou hast faith^{G4102}, and I have works: shew me thy faith^{G4102} without thy works, and I will shew thee my faith^{G4102} by my works.

¹⁹ Thou believest that there is one God; thou doest well: the devils also believe, and tremble.

In James 2 we're given an example of faith without works: and the obvious answer to the question at the end of verse 16 is that there is no profit both for the man or the brother or sister that hath a need. And so we learn that faith without *substance/works/action* is dead. It has no life in it (John 14:6). That means it's dead: there is nothing dead in the kingdom of God: Revelation 21:4.

Matthew 7:24-27

²⁴ Therefore whosoever heareth these sayings of mine, and doeth them, I will liken him unto a wise man, which built his house upon a rock:

²⁵ And the rain descended, and the floods came, and the winds blew, and beat upon that house; and it fell not: for it was founded upon a rock.

²⁶ And every one that heareth these sayings of mine, and doeth them not, shall be likened unto a foolish man, which built his house upon the sand:

²⁷ And the rain descended, and the floods came, and the winds blew, and beat upon that house; and it fell: and great was the fall of it.

Hebrews 11:6

But without faith^{G4102} it is impossible to please him: for he that cometh to God must believe that he is, and that he is a rewarder of them that diligently seek him.

- Take a wild guess which usage of faith it takes to please God: the same word G4102 is translated in Hebrews 11:1 as *substance*. In Titus 2:10 it is translated as "shewing all good fidelity^{G4102}".
- Jesus rewarded the blind men, the centurion, and the man taken with a palsy based on what he saw them do – their actions.

Matthew 16:27

For the Son of man shall come in the glory of his Father with his angels; and then he shall reward every man according to his works.